

ASTR 8500 (O'Connell, Spring 2026)

WRITING A TRIAL PROPOSAL TO THE VIRGINIA SPACE GRANT CONSORTIUM

As an exercise, we are asking each student to **draft a proposal** to the **Virginia Space Grant Consortium** to support their own existing research project (under ASTR 9995).

The VSGC is a NASA program administered through this and other states to support education in areas related to space science and technology. It offers a **\$6000 supplemental fellowship** to graduate students who are working in these areas and who are already supported by their universities.

Our students have been quite successful at securing VSGC support. This year's deadline is already past, but this exercise will be excellent practice if you are interested in applying in the future.

The VSGC Graduate STEM Research Fellowship Program for 2026 is described at [this link](http://vsgc.odu.edu/graduatefellowships/) [http://vsgc.odu.edu/graduatefellowships/].

A sample application form is provided [here](#). In time-honored fashion, the form is somewhat confusing about what you are expected to supply.

Here's what you should do:

1. If you submitted an actual VSGC proposal, ignore the rest of these instructions (except #10) and submit a PDF copy of that.
2. If not, create a **facsimile** of the important parts of the application form and fill out the various box-entry boilerplate (yes, of course it's annoying!)
3. Include the sections that identify your faculty advisor but ignore the request for a second reference-writer. You do not need to request a letter of reference from your advisor.
4. Write a brief personal **resume** according to the instructions. This need not be a full-blown "CV," but if you already have prepared a CV, submit that. See [this page](#) for tips on writing CV's.
5. Write a **brief statement** (not to exceed 750 words) describing "how your research **aligns with NASA's Mission Directorates**." Since the real answer might be "not at all," you may want to exercise some creative skill here.
6. Provide a title and a **research statement** explaining what you intend to do over the 12-month period covered by the award. Minimum 2 pages, maximum 3 pages. Include

references to the literature. This description should be thoughtful and accurately reflect the status and intended goals of your own research.

General tips on writing proposals are given [here](#)

7. Write a **brief statement** (not to exceed 750 words) that describes your short and long term **career goals** (5 and 20 years) and how this research supports your goals.
8. Ignore the "additional comments" entry.
9. Produce a **PDF file** of all this material and turn it in by the deadline (TBA).
10. Prepare an **10 min talk** on your proposal to present to the class using **slides** (PowerPoint or equivalent) to illustrate your research program. (You should **rehearse** your talk to be sure it is no longer than 10 min.)



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